

remedy for all manner of gynecological problems, including infection of the uterus and inflammation of the vagina and vulva.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Fenugreek is much used in herbal medicine in North Africa, the Middle East, and India, being esteemed as a remedy for a wide variety of conditions. The nourishing seeds are given during convalescence and to encourage weight gain, especially in anorexia. They are also helpful in lowering fever, with some authorities comparing their ability to that of quinine.

The seeds' soothing effect makes them of value in treating gastritis and gastric ulcers. They are used to induce childbirth and to increase breast-milk production. Fenugreek is also thought to be antidiabetic and to lower blood cholesterol levels. Externally, the seeds may be applied as a paste to treat abscesses, boils, ulcers, and burns, or used as a douche for excessive vaginal discharge.

Research Research indicates that fenugreek seed (preferably powdered) can prove effective in controlling insulin resistance and late-onset diabetes. The seeds help to stabilize blood-sugar levels, though the recommended dosage of seed required is unclear. The seeds also lower blood cholesterol levels. Other potential uses for the seeds include cramping period pains, polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS), and Parkinson's disease. An Iranian clinical trial in 2014 found that 1/10 oz (2–3 g) of powdered seed helped to reduce menstrual cramps.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy.



Fenugreek seeds

Trillium erectum (Liliaceae) Bethroot

Description Attractive perennial with an erect stem growing to 16 in (40 cm). Has 3 wavy leaves and an unpleasant-smelling, 3-petaled, red to yellow flower.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, bethroot grows in shady areas in woodlands. The rhizome is usually unearthened after the leaves have fallen in autumn.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Bethroot contains steroidal saponins (such as trillin), tannin, resin, fixed oil, and a trace of volatile oil.

History & Folklore Various *Trillium* species were used by Native Americans to aid childbirth, to treat irregular menstrual periods, period pain and excessive vaginal discharge, and, as a poultice, to soothe sore nipples.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bethroot is a valuable remedy for heavy menstrual or

intermenstrual bleeding, helping to reduce blood flow. It is also used to treat bleeding associated with uterine fibroids. Bethroot may also be taken for bleeding within the urinary tubules and, less commonly, for the coughing up of blood. It remains a valuable herb in facilitating childbirth. A douche of bethroot is useful for excessive vaginal discharge and yeast infections.

Caution Do not take during pregnancy except under professional supervision.

Tropaeolum majus (Tropaeolaceae) Nasturtium

Description Climbing annual growing to 10 ft (3m). Has straggling stems, rounded leaves, and orange to yellow trumpet-shaped flowers with a long spur.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Peru, nasturtiums flourish in sunny sites. They are grown as an ornamental and as a salad herb. All parts of the plant are harvested in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, leaves, seeds.

Constituents Nasturtiums contain glucosinolates, sulphur glycosides, glucotropaeolin, flavonoids, spilantolic acid, and iodide. Glucotropaeolin is converted into mustard oils by gut bacteria and acts as an antibiotic within the urinary and respiratory systems.

History & Folklore The nasturtium has long been used in Andean herbal medicine as a disinfectant and wound-healing herb, and as an expectorant to relieve chest conditions.



Nasturtium flowers have antibiotic properties, and may be used to heal wounds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses All parts of the nasturtium appear to have antibiotic activity. An infusion of the leaves may be used to increase resistance to bacterial infections and to clear nasal and bronchial congestion—apparently the remedy both reduces congestion formation and stimulates the clearing and coughing up of phlegm. It can also prove useful in bacterial cystitis and it makes an effective antiseptic wash for external application. The juice of the plant has been taken internally for the treatment of scrofula (tubercular infection of the lymph nodes). The piquant-tasting leaves and flowers (and juice) of nasturtium are high in vitamin C, and make a good salad vegetable, while the ground seeds have purgative properties.

Tsuga canadensis (Pinaceae) Canada Hemlock

Description Evergreen tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has reddish-brown bark, short narrow needle leaves, and small male and female cones.

Habitat & Cultivation Canada hemlock is native to eastern parts of North America, growing in woodland and marshy sites. The bark is collected from mature trees throughout the year.

Part Used Bark.

Constituents Canada hemlock contains volatile oil (with alpha-pinene, bornyl acetate, and cadinene), 10–14% tannins, and resin.

History & Folklore Native Americans may have given Canada hemlock to the explorer Jacques Cartier in 1535. He and his crew, exploring the St. Lawrence river, had fallen sick with scurvy, but all made a quick recovery upon taking a decoction of leaves and bark. Many Native American peoples used the bark to treat wounds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The bark of Canada hemlock is astringent and antiseptic. A decoction may be taken to treat diarrhea, colitis, diverticulitis, and cystitis. Externally, Canada hemlock can be employed as a douche to treat excessive vaginal discharge, yeast infection, and a prolapsed uterus; as a mouthwash and gargle for gingivitis and sore throats; or as a wash to cleanse and tighten wounds.

Tussilago farfara (Asteraceae) Coltsfoot

Description Perennial herb growing to 12 in (30 cm). Has flowering stems with purple scales, yellow-gold flowers, and heart-shaped leaves.

Habitat & Cultivation Indigenous to Europe and northern Asia, and naturalized in